

TikTok Mastery From Scratch (2026)

BrandGoblin AI

Contents

TikTok Mastery From Scratch (2026)	2
The brutally honest guide for Fox, a complete TikTok beginner, building an account from zero to drive BrandGoblin AI signups.	2
HOW TO USE THIS DOC	2
1. HOW TIKTOK ACTUALLY WORKS, IN PLAIN ENGLISH	2
2. THE BRUTAL TRUTHS, UP FRONT	3
3. ACCOUNT SETUP, STEP BY STEP	4
Step 1: Create the account	4
Step 2: Personal account, not Business (for now)	4
Step 3: Profile setup, exact settings	5
Step 4: Warm the account up before posting (3 to 5 days)	5
Step 5: While you are at it	5
4. THE ANATOMY OF A VIDEO THAT WORKS	6
Part 1: The hook (seconds 0 to 3)	6
Part 2: The body (seconds 3 to ~20)	6
Part 3: The payoff (the last 20 percent)	6
Part 4: The CTA (call to action, the ask)	7
The supporting cast: sounds, hashtags, timing (myths sorted from facts)	7
5. THE FORMATS THAT WORK FOR BRANDGOBLIN, RANKED	7
Format 1: The absurd-idea demo (your bread and butter, 3 to 4 per week)	8
Format 2: Comment-reply videos (the growth loop, start week 1, scale forever)	8
Format 3: The founder story (“I built an app that...”)	8
Format 4: Before/after transformation	9
Format 5: Photo carousels (the cheap extra shots on goal)	9
Format 6: Nix-personality clips (the love-builder, 1 per week)	9
6. THE REPEATABLE ONE-PERSON SYSTEM	10
7. READING THE NUMBERS	10
8. TURNING VIEWS INTO SIGNUPS	11
9. MISTAKES THAT KILL ACCOUNTS (THE BLUNT LIST)	12
10. THE 30-DAY TIKTOK CALENDAR (SLOTS INTO THE ACQUISITION PLAN)	13
11. WHAT TO HAND TO AI AND AUTOMATION, HONESTLY	14
12. SOURCES	14

TikTok Mastery From Scratch (2026)

The brutally honest guide for Fox, a complete TikTok beginner, building an account from zero to drive BrandGoblin AI signups.

Written July 5, 2026, from fresh 2025-2026 research. Sources with links at the bottom. Companion docs: [NIX_TIKTOK_PLAYBOOK.md](#) (strategy and content pillars, still good) and [CUSTOMER_ACQUISITION_PLAN_100_USERS_30_DAYS.md](#) (the master plan this slots into). Where new research contradicts the older playbook, this doc says so out loud and wins.

HOW TO USE THIS DOC

Read sections 1 and 2 once, slowly. They rewire how you think about TikTok. Then treat sections 3 through 10 as checklists you come back to. Section 10 is your calendar. Everything is written assuming you have never opened the app, because you basically haven't.

Quick promise on honesty: your 30-day goal is 15 to 30 signups from TikTok. That is achievable. Going viral, getting famous, or building a big following in 30 days is not a plan, it is a lottery ticket. This guide is built for the achievable goal, with the lottery ticket as a free bonus if it hits.

1. HOW TIKTOK ACTUALLY WORKS, IN PLAIN ENGLISH

What TikTok is, mechanically. TikTok is an app where people scroll an endless feed of short vertical videos. The main feed is called the **For You Page**, or **FYP**. It is not a feed of accounts you follow. It is a feed the app builds for each person, one video at a time, based on what it thinks that specific person will watch. This one fact changes everything: on TikTok, people mostly see videos from strangers, chosen by a computer.

The computer choosing the videos is “the algorithm.” That word just means the ranking system that decides which videos get shown to which people. Here is how it treats every new video you post, step by step:

1. **The test batch.** When you post, TikTok shows your video to a small test audience, typically a few hundred people (commonly cited range: 200 to 500 viewers) who it thinks might like this kind of content. You do not need a single follower for this to happen. Every video gets a tryout. ([go-viral.app](#), [outfame.com](#))
2. **The grading.** TikTok watches how that test audience behaves. The signals that matter most, in rough order: how long people watch (**watch time**), whether they watch to the end (**completion rate**), whether they watch it twice (**rewatches**), whether they share it or save it, whether they comment. Likes are the weakest signal of the bunch. Shares sent to friends in direct messages are weighted roughly 3 times more than likes. ([posteverywhere.ai](#), [darkroomagency.com](#))
3. **The escalation.** If the test batch grades well, the video goes to a bigger audience (thousands to tens of thousands), gets graded again, and keeps escalating as long as the numbers hold. Videos watched to at least 85 percent completion have been reported to get around a 4x distribution boost versus videos below that line. ([go-viral.app](#))

4. **The lifespan.** The main push happens in the first 24 to 72 hours, and most of a video's views land within the first 1 to 5 days. But videos are not dead after that. TikTok re-evaluates old videos, and "delayed virality" is real: a video can take off weeks or months later, especially if its topic or sound starts trending, or if it keeps getting found through TikTok search. (topqlearn.com, socialinsider.io)

Why followers matter less than you think. TikTok has officially confirmed follower count is not a direct factor in recommendations. Every video is judged on its own performance with its own test audience. A zero-follower account can get a million views on video one, and a 100k-follower account can post a dud that dies at 400 views. Followers help a little (some of them get shown your new posts, which warms up the test batch), but on TikTok, the video is the unit of success, not the account. (likes.io, beatstorapon.com)

Do new accounts get a boost? There is no confirmed "new account boost." What new accounts do get is a calibration period: TikTok does not yet know who to show your stuff to, so your first weeks can be slow and jumpy while it figures out your niche. This is normal, not a punishment. (shortimize.com)

How TikTok figures out what your video is about. It reads everything: your spoken words (it transcribes audio), text you put on screen, your caption (the text under the video), your hashtags, and what kind of people engage. Captions with clear keywords now matter more than hashtags for getting discovered, with keyword-rich captions reported to boost visibility 20 to 40 percent. Treat every video like a tiny search result: say and show the words your ideal viewer would search, like "brand," "logo," "small business," "AI." (posteverywhere.ai)

One-line summary of the whole platform: make a video a stranger watches to the end, and TikTok will find you an audience. Fail that, and nothing else you do matters.

2. THE BRUTAL TRUTHS, UP FRONT

Read these before you post anything, so nothing here demoralizes you later.

1. **Your first videos will get 50 to 500 views. That is normal.** Multiple sources put a new account's typical early videos in that range while TikTok calibrates. There is even a community nickname, "200 view jail," for the phase where everything seems stuck around 200 views. It is not a ban and it does not mean your content is bad. ([tiktok.com discover pages](https://tiktok.com/discover/pages), admanage.ai)
2. **There is no magic video number where you "make it."** No source gives a reliable "your 14th video pops" rule. The honest pattern from creators who grew: post consistently for weeks, most videos do nothing, one eventually overperforms, then you make ten more like it. One fitness app (Stronger, \$600k per year) found one working format and posted variations of it 300 times. Volume plus repetition of winners is the actual formula. (superwall.com)
3. **A realistic first month:** 20 to 30 posts, most under 1,000 views, a handful in the 1,000 to 10,000 range if you execute well, and maybe one outlier. One documented real account averaged 276 views per video in month one and 253 in month three. Growth is lumpy, not a line. If TikTok sends your site even 300 to 500 visitors this month, your 15 to 30 signup goal is in play at normal conversion rates. (shortimize.com)
4. **Most business accounts flop for one reason: they make ads.** Polished, salesy, logo-first content gets scrolled past instantly, and the algorithm buries anything people skip. Raw,

phone-shot, personality-first content beats polished ads 3 to 5x on conversion metrics. Your acquisition plan already knows this. The winning move is content that entertains first and sells almost accidentally. (inbeat.agency, stackmatix.com)

5. **Shadowbans: partly real, mostly folklore.** A “shadowban” means TikTok quietly limits your reach without telling you. TikTok never uses that word officially, but “content distribution prioritization” (soft suppression of accounts it distrusts) is documented behavior. What actually triggers suppression: spammy behavior (mass posting 15 to 20 times a day, mass following, mass commenting), reposting videos with another app’s watermark, engagement bait (“like if you agree,” “wait for it,” “link in bio for the secret” with no real value), guideline violations, and behaving like a bot on a brand-new account. What does not trigger it: posting the same video on TikTok and Instagram (platforms cannot see each other’s uploads), using an editing app, or criticizing TikTok. Suppression typically fades in 14 to 30 days if you stop the behavior. (shopify.com, socialync.io, auditsocials.com)
 6. **Views convert to clicks at low single digits, and clicks convert to signups at low single digits.** Ballpark math from ad and organic benchmarks: about 1 percent of viewers might visit your profile or click through, and 2 to 5 percent of site visitors sign up for a good free product. So 10,000 views might mean roughly 100 visits and 3 to 8 signups. This is why your 30-day TikTok goal is 15 to 30 signups, not 500. It also means one genuinely viral video (100k+ views) can hit your whole month’s goal alone. (tikadsuite.com, adsmcp.com)
 7. **The grind is the price. There is no way around it.** You will post to near-silence for one to three weeks. Every account you admire went through the same tunnel. The people who win are simply the ones still posting when the calibration ends.
-

3. ACCOUNT SETUP, STEP BY STEP

Jargon for this section. “Bio” is the short text on your profile page. “Handle” or “username” is your @name. “Niche” is the one topic your account is about. “Posting natively” means uploading your video file directly inside each app (TikTok, Instagram, YouTube) instead of sharing a link or a watermarked download from another app. Native posts get full reach; watermarked reposts get buried.

Step 1: Create the account

1. Download TikTok, sign up with your email (joeherrington369@gmail.com or a business email, either is fine).
2. **Username:** `brandgoblinai` if free, otherwise `brandgoblin.ai` or `nixthegoblin`. Rule: it should be the product name or the mascot name, easy to say out loud, because your voiceover will literally say “search BrandGoblin AI.”
3. Use your real phone number for account recovery. Turn on two-factor login. Losing this account later would hurt.

Step 2: Personal account, not Business (for now)

This is the important tradeoff, and it changed recently, so here is the honest 2026 picture: - **Personal accounts** get the full music library, including the trending songs that ride the algorithm. **Business accounts** are limited to a smaller “commercial” music library and lose most trending sounds, which measurably hurts reach. (blog.hootsuite.com, printify.com) - **The clickable bio**

link: historically personal accounts needed 1,000 followers to make their bio link clickable, while business accounts got a clickable link immediately. Multiple 2024-2026 sources now conflict: some say TikTok scrapped the 1,000-follower rule for personal accounts, others say it still applies. TikTok rolls changes out unevenly, so the only reliable answer is to check your own app: Profile, Edit profile, look for a Website field. ([stan.store](#), [socialrails.com](#), [unilink](#)) - **The play for you:** start Personal for the full music library. If your app gives you the website field right away, great, add the link. If it does not, use the pre-1k workarounds in section 8, and know that switching Personal to Business and back is free, takes a minute, and is reversible, so you can flip to Business temporarily if a video blows up and you desperately need the clickable link that week. Do not flip back and forth constantly. - One more 2026 note: analytics (your video stats) are available on personal accounts too, under Profile, Menu, TikTok Studio. You do not need a Business account for numbers.

Step 3: Profile setup, exact settings

- **Profile photo:** Nix's face, the canonical art, cropped close so he reads at thumbnail size.
- **Bio (80 characters max):** state what happens and where. Example: Type your business idea. Nix builds the whole brand in 2 min (wizard emoji) [brandgoblinai.com](#). Even when the URL is not clickable, people can read it and type it. Keep it as plain text in the bio from day one.
- **Website field (if available):** <https://brandgoblinai.com/?ref=tiktok>. The <https://> prefix is required or TikTok will not make it clickable. The [?ref=tiktok](#) part is your tracking tag from the acquisition plan, so you know signups came from TikTok. Links must be added from the phone app, not the website. ([unilink](#))
- **One niche, one account.** This account is about one thing: an AI goblin that builds brands for small business ideas. Do not post your lunch, gym clips, or unrelated humor here. The algorithm builds a profile of what your account is about; mixed signals mean it never learns who to show you to. If you ever want a personal account, make a separate one.

Step 4: Warm the account up before posting (3 to 5 days)

“Warming up” means using the app like a normal human before you ever post, so TikTok does not flag your fresh account as a bot. Honest evidence note: this advice comes from practitioner experience and industry guides, not from TikTok officially, so treat it as cheap insurance rather than proven law. It costs you nothing because you need to do it anyway for a different reason: **you cannot make TikToks well if you have never watched TikToks.** - For 3 to 5 days, 20 to 30 minutes a day: scroll the FYP, and deliberately watch, like, comment on, and follow accounts in your niche (small business content, AI tools, branding, design, entrepreneur content, mascot accounts like Duolingo). - This does two things: it teaches the algorithm your account's neighborhood, and it trains YOUR eye. Note every video that stops your thumb and ask why. That instinct is the whole skill. - Complete your profile during this window, watch some ads (notice how you can smell them instantly, that smell is what you must avoid), and search “AI branding,” “logo design,” “small business tips” to see what already exists. ([tokportal.com](#), [superscale.ai](#))

Step 5: While you are at it

- Create the matching Instagram and YouTube accounts (same name, same bio, same avatar) because every video you make will be posted to all three (section 6). Instagram bio links are clickable immediately with zero followers, which quietly solves part of your link problem: your TikTok bio can say “link on our Instagram” until TikTok gives you the link.

4. THE ANATOMY OF A VIDEO THAT WORKS

Every good TikTok has four parts. Learn these once and you can judge any script in ten seconds.

Part 1: The hook (seconds 0 to 3)

A **hook** is the first thing viewers see and hear, designed to stop them from scrolling. It is the single highest-leverage element of the entire video. The numbers: - The first 2 to 3 seconds decide the majority of your retention. Videos keeping 70 to 85 percent of viewers past 3 seconds get about 2.2x more total views. Below 60 percent retention at 3 seconds, the algorithm mostly stops promoting. (ttsvibes.com, socialync.io) - Hooks that land in the first second get 41 percent higher retention. Translation: no intros, no logo cards, no “hey guys, welcome back.” Frame one is the hook. (retensis.com) - In a 34,635-clip study, the best-performing hook type was **leading with the product in action or the transformation** (show the result immediately), averaging about 2x the views of the weakest hook type. Other proven types: the curiosity gap (an open question the video answers), the bold claim, the identity call (“POV: you...” which names the exact viewer), and the number (“\$0 and 2 minutes vs a \$5,000 agency”). (opus.pro) - Put the hook in three channels at once: what is on screen (something already happening), what you say (your voiceover is your superpower, use it from word one), and text on screen (a **text overlay**, a short line burned onto the video, which also feeds the algorithm keywords).

Part 2: The body (seconds 3 to ~20)

- **Length, 2026 data:** videos under 15 seconds get around 92 percent completion and punch above their weight. The commonly cited virality sweet spot is roughly 11 to 34 seconds. Longer only when the content earns it. A 30-second video watched 80 percent through beats a 60-second video watched 40 percent through, every time. **Your default: 15 to 30 seconds. Your demo-with-story videos: up to 35. Never over 60 this month.** (marketingltb.com, go-viral.app, retensis.com)
 - Note: this slightly updates the old playbook’s “keep most videos 7-15s.” Ultra-short still works, but 2026 data supports 15 to 30 seconds as the better default when you have an actual transformation to show, which you do.
- Cut ruthlessly. On TikTok, any 1-second stretch where nothing changes is where people leave. Change the shot, the text, or what you are saying every 2 to 3 seconds.
- Talk like a person. Your natural voice, slightly faster than feels normal, no announcer voice. Announcer voice smells like an ad.
- **Captions** (subtitles) on everything: a large share of people watch muted, and the caption text doubles as algorithm keywords. CapCut auto-generates them in one tap (section 6).

Part 3: The payoff (the last 20 percent)

The moment the hook promised. For BrandGoblin this is almost always the reveal: the full brand kit appearing from a silly one-line idea. Two rules: - The payoff must be visually satisfying (the montage of name, colors, logo appearing beats a static screenshot). - End IMMEDIATELY after the payoff, or loop back to the start. Videos that end abruptly right at the payoff get rewatches, and rewatches are a heavy ranking signal. A dead second after the payoff kills your completion rate.

Part 4: The CTA (call to action, the ask)

- Keep it soft and short: half a second of Nix plus “it’s free, link in bio” or “search BrandGoblin AI.” Hard selling in-video reads as an ad and tanks retention.
- Never say “like and follow for more” as a bare demand, and never do “wait for it” or “link in bio for the secret.” TikTok explicitly suppresses engagement bait now, with bait-style hooks reported down about 70 percent in reach. Asking a genuine question (“what should Nix brand next?”) is fine and is not bait, because comments answering a real question are real engagement. (auditsocials.com, clippie.ai)
- The heavy CTA lives outside the video: bio, pinned comment, and reply-to-comment videos (section 8).

The supporting cast: sounds, hashtags, timing (myths sorted from facts)

- **Trending sounds: still real.** Using a currently rising sound measurably improves your odds of distribution, especially early in the trend. How to find them: in the app, tap Create, tap Add sound, and browse the trending list, or check the free chart at tokchart.com, or TikTok’s own Creative Center. When you talk over a video, keep a trending sound underneath at low volume (10 to 20 percent), you get the categorization benefit without drowning your voice. (buffer.com, dashesocial.com)
- **Hashtags: mostly myth in 2026, small kernel of truth.** #fyp and #viral do nothing, TikTok has said so directly. Hashtags are a minor categorization assist at best. Use 2 to 5 specific ones (#smallbusiness #branding #aitools #entrepreneur) and spend zero further thought on them. Your caption keywords matter more. This updates the old playbook, which leaned harder on hashtags as a categorization pillar. (heropost.io, sproutsocial.com)
- **Posting times: mostly myth.** Big studies (Buffer analyzed 7.1 million posts) find mild patterns, but every serious source agrees timing is one of the weakest variables on TikTok, because the FYP is not chronological. Pick a consistent slot you can sustain (evenings work fine), and let your own analytics tell you later. A great video at a bad time beats a mediocre video at the perfect time, always. (buffer.com, apaya.com)
- **Posting frequency: 1 a day is the sweet spot for you.** Data says going from 1 post a week to 2-5 a week gives the biggest jump in views per post, and consistent creators see far better engagement than sporadic ones. Some 2026 guides push 3 to 5 posts a day for small accounts; ignore that, it is a content-farm pace that will burn you out by day 10 and push quality below the bar. One good post a day, minimum 4 to 5 a week, matches your acquisition plan and the evidence. (buffer.com, sociallyin.com)
- **Native feel beats polish.** Worth repeating with its number: raw, phone-shot, person-talking content outperforms polished ad-style content by 3 to 5x on conversion metrics, and roughly three quarters of ad-like videos lose the viewer in the first 3 seconds precisely because they look like ads. Your lack of production experience is genuinely an advantage here. (inbeat.agency, stackmatix.com)

5. THE FORMATS THAT WORK FOR BRANDGOBLIN, RANKED

Ranked by expected value for an app with a filmable magic moment, based on what worked for comparable apps (Cal AI grew to hundreds of thousands of monthly downloads on demo-led TikTok content before layering on creators and ads; PushScroll got 80k views and validated a \$30k per

month app from simple demo videos; Stronger repeated one working format 300 times). (growwithplutus.com, blog.classyendeavors.com, superwall.com)

Filming note used everywhere below: “screen recording” means recording your phone or computer screen while you use the app (iPhone: Control Center, Screen Recording button). You then talk over it in CapCut. Your voice is the production value.

Format 1: The absurd-idea demo (your bread and butter, 3 to 4 per week)

The product’s magic moment, framed as entertainment by making the input ridiculous. The comedy is the idea, the wow is the output, the app sells itself.

Worked script, 22 seconds, “candle shop for people who hate candles”: - **0:00-0:03** ON SCREEN: the app’s input box, your finger already typing. TEXT OVERLAY: “I asked an AI goblin to brand the world’s dumbest business.” VOICEOVER: “I’m asking this AI goblin to brand a candle shop... for people who hate candles.” - **0:03-0:06** ON SCREEN: tap Generate. Cut instantly to the loading moment, then the brand name appearing. VO: “It’s actually doing it.” - **0:06-0:16** ON SCREEN: fast montage, one element per 2 seconds: name, tagline, color palette, logo art, a social post. Zoom in on the best detail. VO reacts naturally: “The name is genuinely good. Why is the name good? Look at the tagline. This took ninety seconds.” - **0:16-0:21** ON SCREEN: the finished kit, static Nix PNG slides in from the corner. VO (Nix voice, one line): “Next idea.” TEXT OVERLAY: “BrandGoblin AI. Free. No card.” - **0:21-0:22** Hard cut to black on the word “Next.” No outro. - CAPTION: “A full brand from one dumb sentence. What should Nix brand next? (point-down emoji) #smallbusiness #aitools #branding” PINNED COMMENT: link plus “it’s free, no card.”

Format 2: Comment-reply videos (the growth loop, start week 1, scale forever)

TikTok lets you reply to any comment with a new video; the comment appears as a sticker on screen. These videos get shown to already-engaged viewers and often outperform originals, each one is a personalized product demo, and the commenter shares it because it is about them. This is your single best conversion format. (alkai.ai, hangryfeed.com)

Worked script, 18 seconds, replying to “do a dog bakery”: - **0:00-0:02** ON SCREEN: the comment sticker visible at top. You typing “dog bakery” into the app. VO: “You asked for a dog bakery. Nix, go.” - **0:02-0:12** ON SCREEN: generate, then the reveal montage. VO: “Okay the name... stop it. The colors are perfect. There’s a whole story. Your dog bakery is more branded than most real bakeries.” - **0:12-0:17** ON SCREEN: full kit on screen, Nix PNG pop-in. VO: “Drop your idea in the comments and Nix will brand it. Seriously, any idea.” - **0:17-0:18** Cut. CAPTION: “Part 7 of branding your comments.” (Numbering it as a series makes people binge the others.)

Format 3: The founder story (“I built an app that...”)

Founder-led authenticity consistently outperforms brand-voice content for apps. You talking to camera (or over b-roll of you working) about building a goblin that makes brands. Post 1 per week, no more, this builds connection and followers rather than direct signups.

Worked script, 28 seconds: - **0:00-0:03** ON SCREEN: you, phone-camera selfie angle, mid-thought, no greeting. TEXT: “I built an app where a goblin builds your brand.” VO: “So I built an app where a little green goblin builds your entire brand, and I need to explain myself.” - **0:03-0:15**

ON SCREEN: cut between you and quick app shots. VO: “Every person I know with a business idea gets stuck the same way. Not the idea. The name, the logo, looking real. Designers cost thousands. So I made Nix. You type the idea, he does the rest, under two minutes.” - **0:15-0:24** ON SCREEN: one fast reveal montage of a great kit. VO: “Name, story, colors, logo, launch plan. That one took 100 seconds.” - **0:24-0:28** ON SCREEN: back to you, shrug. VO: “It’s free, I’m a solo founder, I read every comment. Tell me what to make Nix brand next.” CAPTION: “Day 1 of goblin-posting. #buildinpublic #aitools”

Format 4: Before/after transformation

The strongest hook type in the data is the transformation. Show the sad “before” (napkin scribble, ugly DIY logo, blank page), then the kit.

Worked script, 15 seconds: - **0:00-0:03** ON SCREEN: a genuinely bad hand-drawn logo sketch on paper. TEXT: “POV: you have a business idea but can’t afford a designer.” VO: “This was the logo I could afford.” - **0:03-0:05** ON SCREEN: typing the same idea into the app. VO: “Then I typed one sentence.” - **0:05-0:13** Reveal montage. VO: “A designer quoted three grand. The goblin did it in under two minutes. Free.” - **0:13-0:15** Nix pop-in, TEXT: “BrandGoblin AI, link in bio.” Cut.

Format 5: Photo carousels (the cheap extra shots on goal)

A **carousel** (also called photo mode or slideshow) is a post made of still images people swipe through, with music. TikTok has pushed these hard: carousels get around 81 percent higher engagement than comparable videos, and TikTok’s own materials have cited up to 172 percent more views for photo posts, though sources agree videos still edge them on raw plays. For you they are nearly free content: every brand kit Nix generates is 5 to 6 beautiful slides. (socialinsider.io, instacarousel.com)

Worked example: Slide 1: “An AI goblin branded a taco truck run by grandmas. Swipe.” Slide 2: the name and tagline, big. Slide 3: color palette. Slide 4: logo art. Slide 5: the social post it generated. Slide 6: Nix art plus “your idea next, free, link in bio.” Trending sound underneath. Two of these a week, zero filming required.

Format 6: Nix-personality clips (the love-builder, 1 per week)

The old playbook’s “Nix Lives Here” pillar, downgraded from lead format to seasoning, per the acquisition plan’s verdict: personality now, puppetry later. Static Nix with your goblin voiceover reacting to things (rating brands he made, reacting to comments, “Nix’s opinion on Comic Sans”) builds the character with zero rig. Keep them coming so the account has a soul, but the demo formats pay the bills. When the animated rig lands later, this pillar gets promoted.

Ratio for the month: roughly 80 percent value/wow/entertainment (formats 1, 2, 4, 5) and 20 percent founder and mascot connection (formats 3, 6). Never more than 1 in 5 videos feeling like a direct pitch.

6. THE REPEATABLE ONE-PERSON SYSTEM

Gear check: your phone is enough. Verified repeatedly: phone camera plus daylight from a window beats a studio setup for TikTok-native feel. The only purchase worth considering is a \$15 to \$20 clip-on microphone if your voiceovers sound roomy, and even that can wait, since you can record voiceovers into CapCut directly in a quiet closet.

CapCut, your one editing tool. CapCut is a free video editing app (same parent company as TikTok) for phone or desktop. The free tier does everything you need: cutting, text overlays, one-tap auto captions, voiceover recording, speed ramps, the Nix PNG pop-ins. Exports are watermark-free for normal edits; some templates and Pro features add branding, so avoid templates and you are fine. CapCut Pro is about \$10 a month and unnecessary this month (your acquisition plan's \$50 tools buffer covers it later if you want it). (fluxnote.io, capcutpro-apks.com)

Time budget per video, realistic: screen-record the generation (5 min), write or tighten the script (10 min), record voiceover (10 min), edit in CapCut with captions and text overlays (25 to 40 min while learning, 15 to 20 once practiced). Call it 45 to 60 minutes per video at first, dropping toward 30. Carousels: 15 minutes.

The weekly rhythm: - Batch day (Sunday, 2 to 3 hours): generate 4 to 6 brand kits in the app (pull ideas from comments first, absurd ideas second). Screen-record all of them in one sitting. Record all voiceovers in one sitting (your voice is warmed up, takes get faster). Edit 2 to 3 videos fully, leave the rest as drafts. - **Weekdays (20 to 30 min per day):** finish or polish one draft, post it, then do the daily routine below. - **The daily 20-minute routine, non-negotiable:** 1. Reply to every comment on your videos, fastest within the first hour after posting (early engagement helps ranking, and every idea-comment is future content). 2. Flag the 1 to 2 best comment ideas for the next batch day. 3. Spend 5 minutes scrolling your niche and leaving 2 to 3 genuine comments from the account (keeps the account looking human and puts your name in front of your exact audience). 4. Log your numbers in the daily scorecard from the acquisition plan.

One video becomes three posts (TikTok + Instagram Reels + YouTube Shorts). Reels and Shorts are Instagram's and YouTube's TikTok-clone feeds. The rules for repurposing correctly: 1. Edit in CapCut, export the clean file to your camera roll FIRST. Never download your video from TikTok to repost elsewhere: TikTok downloads carry a TikTok watermark, and Instagram and YouTube actively suppress watermarked videos. (routenote.com, socialk.it) 2. Upload the clean file natively inside each app. There is no cross-platform duplicate-content penalty; the platforms cannot see each other. (socialync.io) 3. One catch: a trending TikTok sound added inside TikTok exists only in that post. For the Reels and Shorts copies, either add each platform's own trending audio inside that app, or just let your voiceover carry it. Voiceover-led videos travel perfectly. 4. Order of operations per video: TikTok first (your main lab), then Reels, then Shorts, 5 extra minutes total.

7. READING THE NUMBERS

Where to look: your profile, menu (three lines, top right), TikTok Studio, Analytics. Tap any video for its own stats. Give any video 48 hours before judging it, since the main push runs 24 to 72 hours.

The five numbers that matter, what good looks like, and the decision rules:

Metric	Plain-English meaning	Good for you	Bad sign
3-second hold / retention graph	% of viewers still there at second 3 (read it off the video's retention curve)	65%+	under 50%: the hook failed
Completion rate	% who watched to the very end	60%+ on a 15-30s video (under-15s videos average 60-70% platform-wide, 75%+ is strong)	under 40%: the middle is boring or too long
Average watch time	seconds the average viewer stayed	more than half your video length	a cliff in the retention graph shows the exact second you lost them, fix that beat next video
Shares + saves	people sent it to a friend or bookmarked it	share rate above 1% of views is great, 2%+ is exceptional	zero shares on 1,000+ views: nobody thinks anyone else needs this
Profile visits → link clicks	viewers who came to your page, then clicked out	roughly 1% of views turning into profile visits is healthy; watch clicks in the link tool or your site analytics	high views, no profile visits: entertaining but nobody cares who made it, strengthen the Nix/app presence

Benchmarks from retensis.com, influenceflow.io, and marketingagent.blog.

The decision rules (run weekly, on batch day): - **Kill a format** after 4 to 5 attempts if every attempt sits below your account's median views AND completion is under 40 percent. The format is broken, not the algorithm. - **Keep and iterate** when completion is decent but views are meh: usually a hook problem. Remake the same video with a different first 3 seconds before abandoning the idea. - **Double down** when any video beats your median by 2x or more: make 3 to 5 variations of it within the week (same structure, new idea). This is the entire growth strategy of every app account that made it. - **Boost it** (the acquisition plan's week 3 Spark Ads decision): a video qualifies for the \$150 boost if completion is above average for your account, engagement is at least 1.5x your median, and a total stranger would get it without context. - Ignore likes and follower count day to day. They follow the numbers above; they do not lead them.

8. TURNING VIEWS INTO SIGNUPS

The funnel, honestly: video, profile visit, link click, landing page, signup. Every step leaks. Your job is to make each leak smaller.

Before the clickable link (if your app enforces the 1,000-follower rule): 1. Bio contains the URL as plain text anyway. People do type it. Keep it short and clean: brandgoblinai.com. 2. **Verbal CTA plus search:** “search BrandGoblin AI” spoken in the video works with zero followers and survives every platform’s rules. Also literally say “it’s free” every time, “free, no card” is your strongest single line per the acquisition plan. 3. **Pinned comment on every video:** write a comment with the URL and pin it (tap and hold your comment, Pin). Comment links are not clickable either, but pinned comments get read, and people copy the URL. 4. Instagram bio link is clickable from day zero. Your TikTok bio can say “link in bio on our IG” and the same video is already posted there. 5. If a video truly pops pre-1k, switch to a Business account for that week to unlock the clickable link, accept the music limitation temporarily, and switch back after the wave. Legitimate and reversible.

After 1,000 followers (or if you have the link field already): the link goes live, and every caption ends with a soft “link in bio.” Do not switch to a link-in-bio landing tool (Linktree and friends) yet; one link, straight to the app, converts better than a menu.

CTA wording that works (soft, verbal-first, since your voice is the asset): - “Nix did this in the app. It’s free, link in bio.” - “Search BrandGoblin AI if you want yours.” - “Comment your idea and Nix will brand it.” (This is a CTA disguised as a game, and it feeds Format 2.) - Never: “sign up now,” “don’t miss out,” “limited time.” Ad-smell kills reach before it can convert.

The landing page (matters as much as the videos): TikTok traffic is 100 percent mobile, impatient, and arrives mid-scroll. The page must load in under 3 seconds, look right on a phone, and continue the exact promise of the video, same energy, Nix visible, idea box front and center, “free, no card” above the fold (the part visible without scrolling). If a viewer lands and cannot start typing their idea within one thumb-tap, you lose them. This “message match” between ad and page is one of the highest-impact conversion factors measured. (adsmcp.com, tikadtools.com)

Realistic conversion math to sanity-check your month: organic TikTok converts viewers to site visitors at very roughly 0.5 to 1 percent, and a good free-product landing page converts visitors at 2 to 5 percent (lead-gen style signups can run higher). So: 50,000 total views across the month, roughly 250 to 500 visits, roughly 10 to 25 signups, right on your 15 to 30 target once Reels, Shorts, and the possible Spark Ads boost stack on top. This is why the plan needs volume and repetition, not one hero video. (tikadsuite.com, adsmcp.com)

9. MISTAKES THAT KILL ACCOUNTS (THE BLUNT LIST)

1. **Making ads.** Polished intro, logo card, announcer voice, “sign up today.” Death in 3 seconds, every time.
2. **Reposting videos with watermarks.** TikTok-watermarked video on Reels, or vice versa. Actively suppressed. Always export clean from CapCut.
3. **Engagement bait.** “Wait for it,” “like if you agree,” “follow for part 2” with no real part 2, “link in bio for the secret.” Reach down as much as 70 percent on bait-style content in 2026.
4. **Posting like a bot.** 10 posts on day one of a fresh account, mass following, copy-paste commenting. This is what actually triggers the “shadowban” people complain about.
5. **Quitting at video 12.** The calibration phase is one to three weeks of near-silence. Most accounts die here, which is exactly why the survivors win.
6. **Chasing every niche.** One account, one topic. The goblin brands businesses. That is the

channel.

7. **Deleting “flopped” videos.** Old videos resurface via search and delayed virality. Leave them up; a flop costs nothing.
 8. **Judging a video in the first 3 hours.** The push runs 24 to 72 hours. React on batch day, not in a panic.
 9. **Buying followers or views.** Poisons your test audiences forever (the algorithm learns your content pleases bots, then shows it to no one) and risks the account.
 10. **Answering comments as a corporation.** “Thanks for your feedback!” is invisible. Answer like Fox, or answer as Nix in character. Comment charm is free reach.
 11. **Ignoring the retention graph.** It literally shows the second people leave. Not looking at it means repeating the same mistake 20 times.
 12. **Waiting for perfect.** The animated rig, the better camera, the cleaner edit. The acquisition plan’s verdict stands: ship with static Nix and your voice. A posted 7/10 beats an unposted 10/10 by exactly the number of people who saw it.
-

10. THE 30-DAY TIKTOK CALENDAR (SLOTS INTO THE ACQUISITION PLAN)

This refines the acquisition plan’s video track with everything above. Where the master plan says “first videos ship Day 4,” this keeps that date and adds the warm-up before it.

Days 1-3 (while doing the plan’s funnel check and directory blitz): - Create the TikTok, Instagram, YouTube accounts. Full profiles, bios, tracking links where clickable. - Warm up daily: 20 to 30 minutes of niche scrolling, liking, commenting, following. No posts yet. - Install CapCut, do one throwaway practice edit (never posted) to learn captions, text, voiceover. - Check whether your TikTok gives you the website field (section 3, step 2).

Day 4 (matches plan): first 2 posts. - Post 1: Format 1, absurd-idea demo (use the acquisition plan’s hook bank, e.g. “I gave this AI goblin my dumbest business idea”). - Post 2: Format 2 starter: “Comment a business idea and Nix will brand it. Any idea. I’m not kidding.” - Both cross-posted clean to Reels and Shorts. Pinned comment with URL on everything.

Days 5-7: one post per day (Format 4 before/after on day 6, per the plan; a carousel on day 7). Day 7 is the plan’s batch day: build week 2’s videos, prioritizing comment ideas if any arrived.

Days 8-14 (the plan’s launch-tour week): one post daily on autopilot from the batch. First comment-reply videos go out as soon as real comments exist. Formats this week: 3 demos, 2 comment replies, 1 founder story (“I’m a solo founder launching this everywhere this week, here’s what happened”), 1 carousel. The launch tour and TikTok feed each other: launch-day traffic comments, comments become videos.

Days 15-21 (Product Hunt week + Spark decision): - Keep the daily post. Add a founder-story video about the Product Hunt launch itself (these do well; honest numbers, no bragging). -

Day 18, the boost decision from the master plan: apply section 7’s boost criteria. If a video qualifies, run it as a Spark Ad at \$25 a day for 6 days per the plan’s budget. If nothing qualifies, spend nothing, keep posting, no shame in it. - Weekly review on batch day: kill/keep/double-down on every format using section 7’s rules.

Days 22-30 (amplify and convert): - The comment-reply machine at full speed; number them

as a series (“Branding your ideas, part 9”). - Make 3 to 5 variations of your best-performing video. This week is exploitation, not experiments. - If you crossed 1,000 followers, the bio link goes live everywhere and every caption points at it. - Days 29-30: the honest recap video for TikTok too (“30 days ago I’d never posted a TikTok. Here’s every number.”), same story the plan posts to Reddit and X. Transparency performs.

The month’s honest scoreboard: 25 to 30 posts across formats, 20k to 80k total views if execution is solid (wide range because variance is the nature of the platform), 200 to 800 followers, 15 to 30 signups tagged ?ref=tiktok. A breakout video makes those numbers look silly; the plan does not depend on one.

11. WHAT TO HAND TO AI AND AUTOMATION, HONESTLY

Worth doing (saves hours, costs nothing real): - **Idea generation and scripts:** AI (Claude, or Nix himself as a brainstorm partner) can draft absurd business ideas, hook variations, and full scripts in the section 5 templates. You edit for your voice. This is the biggest legitimate time-saver. - **Caption and hashtag drafting, brand-kit screenshots into carousel layouts, repurposing checklists:** all safely delegable. - **Editing templates:** once you have edited 5 videos, your CapCut project becomes a reusable template (same text styles, same Nix pop-in, same pacing). Semi-automation through repetition. - **Batch scheduling:** TikTok has a built-in scheduler on desktop; free tiers of tools like Metricool (already in the plan’s budget notes) can queue the week.

Not worth automating, and this is the honest part: - **Filming and voiceover.** Your voice and your genuine reactions are the entire moat of this channel. AI voiceovers are detectable and TikTok’s 2026 rules increasingly require AI-content labeling, which changes how content is distributed. Record your own takes; it is 10 minutes a day. (auditsocials.com) - **Replying to comments.** Automated replies read as automated within one exchange, and the comment section is where the Nix character and the growth loop actually live. 15 minutes a day, human only. - **Fully AI-generated videos posted on a schedule.** Faceless AI-content accounts are precisely what the 2026 algorithm has learned to suppress as low-quality. The research is unambiguous that authentic founder-made content is outperforming, not underperforming, automation. - Rule of thumb: automate the paperwork around the content, never the human inside it.

12. SOURCES

Algorithm and distribution - <https://posteverywhere.ai/blog/how-the-tiktok-algorithm-works> - <https://www.go-viral.app/blog/tiktok-algorithm-2026/> - <https://blog.hootsuite.com/tiktok-algorithm/> - <https://likes.io/blog/tiktok-algorithm-2026> - <https://beatstorapon.com/blog/tiktok-algorithm-the-ultimate-guide/> - <https://www.darkroomagency.com/observatory/how-tiktok%E2%80%99s-algorithm-works-in-2026-and-15-tactics-to-go-viral> - <https://www.outfame.com/blog/tiktok-algorithm-2026-drives-fyp-distribution> - <https://topqlearn.com/how-long-tiktok-pushes-video-lifecycle> - <https://www.socialinsider.io/blog/tiktok-virality-insights/> - <https://virlo.ai/blog/how-long-does-it-take-for-a-tiktok-to-go-viral>

Account setup, links, warm-up - <https://blog.hootsuite.com/tiktok-business-vs-personal/> - <https://printify.com/blog/tiktok-business-account-vs-personal/> - <https://stan.store/blog/tiktok->

link-bio-requirements-2026-guide/ - <https://socialrails.com/blog/how-to-add-link-tiktok-bio-complete-guide> - <https://unil.ink/blog/tiktok-link-in-bio-requirements-2026> - <https://app.unilink.us/blog/tiktok-link-in-bio-without-1000-followers> - <https://www.tokportal.com/learn/tiktok-account-warming-guide> - <https://superscale.ai/learn/the-right-way-to-warm-up-new-tiktok-instagram-accounts/> - <https://reel.farm/guides/how-to-warm-up-tiktok-account>

Hooks, length, retention, timing, frequency, sounds, hashtags - <https://insights.ttsvibes.com/tiktok-first-3-seconds-hook-retention-rate/> - <https://www.opus.pro/blog/tiktok-hooks-that-go-viral-2026> - <https://retensis.com/blog/tiktok-retention-rate-benchmarks-2026> - <https://www.socialync.io/blog/tiktok-viral-retention-rate-2026> - <https://www.go-viral.app/blog/tiktok-video-length/> - <https://marketingltb.com/blog/s-videos-statistics/> - <https://buffer.com/resources/how-often-should-you-post-on-tiktok/> - <https://apaya.com/blog/tiktok-time-to-post-on-tiktok> - <https://sociallyin.com/resources/how-often-should-you-post-on-tiktok/> - <https://buffer.com/resources/trending-songs-tiktok/> - <https://tokchart.com/> - <https://www.dashsocial.com/blog/tiktok-sounds> - <https://heropost.io/social-media-hashtags-guide-2026/> - <https://sproutsocial.com/insights/tiktok-hashtags/> - <https://hashtagtools.io/blog/do-hashtags-actually-work-data-analysis-2026>

Realistic expectations, suppression, shadowbans, policy - <https://admanage.ai/blog/average-tiktok-views> - <https://www.shortimize.com/blog/what-is-a-good-view-rate-for-tiktok> - <https://www.shopify.com/uk/news/avoid-shadow-ban> - <https://startups.co.uk/news/what-is-shadowbanning/> - <https://www.socialync.io/blog/avoid-content-duplication-penalties-cross-posting-2026> - <https://www.auditsocials.com/platforms/tiktok-community-guidelines> - <https://www.auditsocials.com/blog/tiktok-ai-content-disclosure-rules-2026> - <https://clippie.ai/blog/tiktok-changes-2026-creators-guide> - <https://www.aivideocut.com/blog/tiktok-shadow-ban-algorithm>

App-account case studies and formats - <https://growwithplutus.com/blog/cal-ai-app-tiktok-strategy> - <https://stormy.ai/blog/cal-ai-tiktok-marketing-playbook-2026> - <https://www.starterstory.com/cal-ai-breakdown> - <https://growthcurve.co/three-engines-and-an-exit-the-cal-ai-growth-playbook> - <https://superwall.com/blog/how-stronger-built-a-usd600k-app-using-viral-on-demand-tiktok-strategy/> - <https://blog.classyendeavors.com/they-made-a-fake-app-demo-got-80k-views-then-built-a-30k-month-business-eb615e3e2f80> - <https://subclub.com/episode/how-to-go-viral-on-tiktok-and-profit-from-it-joseph-choi-viral-app-founders> - <https://www.alkai.ai/post/tiktok-video-replies> - <https://www.hangryfeed.com/insights/posts/tiktok-video-reply-strategy> - <https://www.socialinsider.io/blog/tiktok-carousel/> - <https://instacarousel.com/blog/tiktok-carousel-photo-mode-2026/> - <https://www.tokportal.com/learn/tiktok-carousel-posts-complete-guide-photo-mode>

Production and repurposing - <https://fluxnote.io/guides/capcut-questions-answered> - <https://capcutpro-apks.com/capcut-no-watermark-explained/> - <https://routenote.com/blog/does-instagram-penalise-tiktok-or-capcut-content/> - <https://socialk.it/en/blog/tiktok-watermark-reach-guide>

Analytics and conversion - <https://influenceflow.io/resources/tiktok-creator-metrics-the-complete-2026-guide-to-tracking-analyzing-optimizing-your-performance/> - <https://planable.io/blog/tiktok-metrics/> - <https://marketingagent.blog/2025/12/31/tiktok-profile-views-in-2026-the-conversion-metric-that-separates-viral-content-from-real-growth/> - <https://tikadsuite.com/tiktok-conversion-rate-calculator/> - <https://adsmcp.com/blog/tiktok-landing-page-conversion-optimization/> - <https://tikadtools.com/blog/tiktok-ads-landing-page/> - <https://inbeat.agency/blog/ugc-statistics> - <https://www.stackmatix.com/blog/ugc-ads-strategy-for-brands>

Evidence-quality note. TikTok publishes almost nothing official about its ranking system, so nearly every specific number above (the 4x completion multiplier, the 2.2x retention effect, the 200-500 test batch) comes from third-party studies and practitioner analysis, not TikTok itself. The

numbers converge across independent sources, which is why they are trusted here, but treat them as strong estimates, not physics. The three claims with genuinely conflicting sources are flagged inline: the 1,000-follower link rule (check your own app), account warm-up (plausible, unproven, costs nothing), and carousel view counts (engagement gain is solid, raw-view gain is disputed).